Preliminary report: card-gateway authorization timeouts on 2026-03-12

Document: INC-302

Date: 2026-03-12

Services: card-gateway

Summary

This is a preliminary SEV2 incident report. On 2026-03-12, card-gateway authorization requests experienced a timeout of 8 seconds, causing payment processing failures. The Card Gateway team identified slow responses from NorthBank as the likely cause and escalated to the NorthBank operations desk for investigation. The full postmortem is documented in INC-301.

Impact

Merchants were unable to process card payments during the incident window. Authorization requests to NorthBank failed when responses exceeded the timeout of 8 seconds threshold, resulting in declined transactions and degraded service availability.

Timeline

- 14:32 UTC: card-gateway monitoring alerts triggered for elevated authorization timeout rates

- 14:35 UTC: Card Gateway team confirmed slow responses from NorthBank

- 14:40 UTC: Daniel Okafor initiated escalation to NorthBank operations desk

- 15:15 UTC: NorthBank operations desk acknowledged the issue

Root Cause

Slow responses from NorthBank caused authorization requests to exceed the timeout of 8 seconds, resulting in request failures at card-gateway. The underlying cause at NorthBank's infrastructure requires further investigation by their operations team.

Resolution

The Card Gateway team contacted the NorthBank operations desk to investigate the source of slow responses. NorthBank operations worked to restore normal response times. Authorization timeouts subsided as NorthBank's performance recovered.

Follow-up Actions

- Refer to RB-05 for standard procedures during NorthBank authorization timeouts

- Complete full incident analysis in INC-301

- Coordinate with NorthBank to understand root cause and preventive measures

- Review timeout thresholds and alerting sensitivity